associated with it occurred in the 1950s, when a mob threw a high-ranking Slovenian clergyman over it into Italy, in an act masterminded by the Communist authorities.)

The truth was that, from the 1970s onwards, when Yugoslavia liberalised its border regime to allow for the development of its tourist industry and access to hard currency, Yugoslavs were free to travel anywhere they wished and as often as they wished. We were the privileged ones in the Communist world. Coming from a nearby town, I remember well how, in the years of my childhood, we used to go shopping in Italy almost every fortnight, bringing home items that were not available in Yugoslavia or were cheaper in Italy, like jeans, electronics, washing powder, fruits, coffee, etc.

I will return to the deeper significance of 'washing-powder tourism' later, but let me describe one more aspect of Cold War history at the border between Italy and Yugoslavia/Slovenia. Italians were also coming over to Slovenia in almost the same numbers to buy petrol and fresh meat or to indulge in Slovenian restaurants, casinos and good-value dental repairs. (In return, Yugoslav dinars, though not officially a convertible currency, were accepted in the shops of Trieste/Trst and Gorizia/Gorica.) However, those Italian shoppers, gamblers and patients seemed almost completely ignorant about the country (Slovenia) they were visiting. They seemed to know nothing of the centuries of shared history (except perhaps of *esuli*, the Italian refugees from Yugoslavia after World War II, and the *foibe* killing fields, to which I come later), as if Communist rule had simply erased them. In other words, during the Communist era it began to seem perfectly normal that Gorizia/Gorica or Trieste/Trst, with its Slovenian ethnic minority, should be labelled Western European, but that the immediate hinterland of Slovenia should be called an Eastern European land. And yet nobody was able to explain what exactly – other than Communism – made the Slovenian hinterland Eastern European and Trieste/Trst Western European.

In any account of European history, East and West first appear in connection with the Eastern and Western Roman Empire, i.e. the Byzantine Empire (called 'Roman' by Ottomans and Greeks and 'Greek' by the West) and the Latin Roman Empire (later referred to as the Frankish Empire). In 285 AD, the then Roman Emperor Diocletian moved the centre of the empire to the East and divided it in two, drawing the dividing line across